

The Witherspoon Institute

Thomistic Seminar

Tuesday, July 28

The Nature of Happiness

Afternoon Session

Prof. Joseph Stenberg

Readings:

Summa theologiae I-II, q. 2-3

Thomas Aquinas

"Beatitude and the Beatitudes in Aquinas's Summa Theologiae"

Servais Pinckaers

QUESTION 2

The Things That Man's Beatitude Lies In

Next we have to consider beatitude: first, what it lies in (question 2); second, what it is (questions 3-4); and third, how we can attain it (question 5).

On the first topic there are eight questions: (1) Does beatitude lie in riches? (2) Does beatitude lie in honors? (3) Does beatitude lie in fame or glory? (4) Does beatitude lie in power? (5) Does beatitude lie in a bodily good? (6) Does beatitude lie in pleasure? (7) Does beatitude lie in a good of the soul? (8) Does beatitude lie in a created good?

Article 1

Does man's beatitude lie in riches?

It seems that man's beatitude lies in riches (*consistit in divitiis*):

Objection 1: Since beatitude is man's ultimate end, it lies in what most dominates man's affections. But riches are like this, since Ecclesiastes 10:19 says, "All things obey money (*pecuniae obediunt omnia*).” Therefore, man's beatitude lies in riches.

Objection 2: According to Boethius in *De Consolatione Philosophiae* 3, "Beatitude is a state perfected by the aggregation of all goods." But it seems that in money (*in pecuniis*) all things are possessed, since, as the Philosopher says in *Ethics* 5, money (*nummus*) was invented in order to be a guarantee (*fideiussor*), as it were, that a man might have whatever he wanted in exchange for it. Therefore, beatitude lies in riches.

Objection 3: Since the desire for the highest good never goes away (*numquam deficiat*), it seems to be unlimited (*infinitum*). But this is what one finds especially in the case of riches, since, as Ecclesiastes 5:9 says, "An avaricious man (*avarus*) shall not be satisfied with money." Therefore, beatitude lies in riches.

But contrary to this: Man's good lies more in keeping (*in retinendo*) beatitude than in giving it away (*in emittendo*). But as Boethius says in *De Consolatione Philosophiae* 2, "Riches flourish more by being poured out than by being amassed; for avarice always creates loathsome men, while generosity creates illustrious men." Therefore, beatitude does not lie in riches.

I respond: It is impossible for man's beatitude to lie in riches. For as the Philosopher says in *Politics* 1, there are two kinds of riches, viz., *natural* riches and *artificial* riches. Natural riches—e.g., food (*cibus*), drink (*potus*), clothing (*vestimenta*), means of transportation (*vehicula*), housing (*habitacula*), and other things of this sort—are those by which a man is assisted in meeting his natural needs (*ad defectus naturales tollendos*). On the other hand, artificial riches are those such as money (*denarii*), which do not in their own right assist nature, but which human art has introduced to be, as it were, a measure of items for sale in order to facilitate buying and selling (*propter facilitatem commutationis*).

Now it is obvious that man's beatitude cannot lie in natural riches. For riches of this sort are sought for the sake of something else, viz., to sustain man's nature, and so they cannot be a man's ultimate end, but are instead ordered toward the man himself as an end. Hence, in the order of nature all things of this sort are lower than man and are made for the sake of man—this according to Psalm 8:8 ("You have subjected all things under his feet").

On the other hand, artificial riches are sought only for the sake of natural riches, since they would not be sought except that things necessary for one's way of life (*necessariae ad usum vitae*) are bought with them. Hence, artificial riches have even less of the character of an ultimate end.

Therefore, it is impossible that beatitude, which is a man's ultimate end, should lie in riches.

Reply to objection 1: All bodily things "obey money" in the eyes of the multitude of the foolish, who are acquainted only with the bodily goods that can be acquired with money. But one's judgment

about human goods should be taken from the wise and not from the foolish, just as one's judgment about tastes should be taken from those whose sense of taste is well-disposed.

Reply to objection 2: What can be had with money are all the things that are for sale, but not spiritual goods, which cannot be sold. Hence, Proverbs 17:16 says, "What good is it for a fool to have riches, seeing that he cannot buy wisdom?"

Reply to objection 3: The desire for natural riches is not unlimited, since at some fixed point they are sufficient for nature. But the desire for artificial riches is indeed unlimited, since, as is clear from the Philosopher in *Politics* 1, it is subject to a disordered concupiscence that knows no bounds.

However, the desire for the highest good is different from this unlimited desire for riches. For the more perfectly the highest good is possessed, the more it itself is loved and other things disdained. For the more it is had, the better it is known. This is why Ecclesiasticus 24:29 says, "They that eat me shall yet hunger."

By contrast, it is just the opposite with the desire for riches and for temporal goods in general. For once these goods are possessed, they are disdained, and other goods are desired. This is what is meant in John 4:13 when our Lord says, "Whoever drinks of this water [read: temporal goods] will thirst again." The reason for this is that their insufficiency is better understood once they are possessed. And so this very fact shows their imperfection, and it also shows that the highest good does not lie in them.

Article 2

Does man's good lie in honors?

It seems that man's good lies in honors:

Objection 1: As the Philosopher says in *Ethics* 1, beatitude (*beatitudo*), or happiness (*felicitas*), is a reward for virtue. But as the Philosopher says in *Ethics* 4, honor seems especially to be what the reward of virtue is. Therefore, beatitude lies especially in honor.

Objection 2: Beatitude, which is a perfect good, seems especially to be whatever belongs to God and to the most excellent beings. But as the Philosopher says in *Ethics* 4, honor is one of those things. Likewise, in 1 Timothy 1:17 the Apostle says, "To the only God be honor and glory." Therefore, beatitude lies in honor.

Objection 3: Beatitude is whatever is especially desired by men. But nothing seems to be more desirable to men than honor; for men suffer losses in all other things in order not to suffer any loss of honor. Therefore, beatitude lies in honor.

But contrary to this: Beatitude exists in the one who is blessed (*in beato*). However, as the Philosopher points out in *Ethics* 1, honor exists not in the one who is being honored, but rather in the one doing the honoring, who shows reverence for the one being honored. Therefore, beatitude does not lie in honor.

I respond: It is impossible for beatitude to lie in honor. For honor is shown to someone because of some excellence on his part. And so honor is a sign of and testimony to the excellence that exists in the one being honored. But it is a man's excellence that is especially involved in beatitude (*maxime attenditur secundum beatitudinem*), which is man's perfect good, and in the parts of beatitude, i.e., in those goods which participate in beatitude. And so honor can, to be sure, follow upon beatitude, but beatitude cannot lie principally in honor.

Reply to objection 1: As the Philosopher says in the same place, honor is not a reward for virtue in the sense that virtuous men act for the sake of honor; rather, it is in place of a reward that they receive honor from men—as if from men who have nothing greater to give them. Indeed, the real reward for virtue is beatitude itself, and it is for the sake of beatitude that virtuous men act. Moreover, if they did

act for the sake of honor, then this would no longer be virtue, but ambition instead.

Reply to objection 2: Honor is due to God and to the most excellent beings as a sign of or testimony to a preexistent excellence and not because the honor itself makes them excellent.

Reply to objection 3: As has been explained, it is out of a natural desire for beatitude, which gives rise to honor, that men happen especially to desire honor. This is why men seek to be honored especially by the wise, in light of whose judgment they come to believe themselves to be excellent or happy.

Article 3

Does man's beatitude lie in glory or fame?

It seems that man's beatitude lies in glory [or fame]:

Objection 1: Beatitude seems to lie in what is rendered to the saints because of the tribulations they suffered in the world. But this is glory; for in Romans 8:18 the Apostle says, "The sufferings of this time are not worthy to be compared with the glory to come, that shall be revealed in us." Therefore, beatitude lies in glory.

Objection 2: As is clear from Dionysius in *De Divinis Nominibus*, chap. 4, the good is diffusive of itself. But it is through glory that man's good is especially diffused into the knowledge of others, since, as Ambrose says, glory is nothing other than "clear knowledge accompanied by praise (*clara notitia cum laude*).” Therefore, man's beatitude lies in glory.

Objection 3: Beatitude is the most stable of goods. But fame or glory seems to be like this, since it is through fame or glory that a man in some sense attains eternity. Hence, in *De Consolatione Philosophiae* Boethius says, "You seem to propagate immortality for yourselves when you consider your fame in times to come." Therefore, man's beatitude lies in fame or glory.

But contrary to this: Beatitude is man's true good. But it is possible for fame or glory to be false; for as Boethius says in *De Consolatione Philosophiae* 3, "Many men have acquired a great name from the false opinions of the crowd. Can anything be thought more shameful? For those who are falsely lauded must blush to hear their own praises." Therefore, it is not the case that man's beatitude lies in fame or glory.

I respond: It is impossible for man's beatitude to lie in fame or glory. For as Ambrose puts it, glory is nothing other than "clear knowledge accompanied by praise." Now a thing that is known is related in one way to human cognition and in a different way to God's cognition.

For human cognition is caused by the things known, whereas God's cognition is a cause of the things known. Hence, the perfection of the human good, which is called beatitude, cannot be caused by human knowledge; instead, it is human knowledge of someone's beatitude that proceeds from and is in some sense caused by human beatitude itself, either inchoative beatitude or perfect beatitude. And so man's beatitude cannot lie in fame or glory.

By contrast, a man's good depends on God's cognition as its cause. And so the cause which a man's beatitude depends on is the glory he has from God (*gloria quae est apud Deum*)—this according to Psalm 90:15-16 ("I will deliver him, and I will glorify him; I will fill him with length of days, and I will show him my salvation").

There is also another thing to take into consideration, viz., that human ideas (*humana notitia*) are often mistaken, especially with respect to singular contingent things like human acts. And, therefore, human glory is often fallacious. By contrast, since God cannot make a mistake, the glory that comes from Him (*eius gloria*) is always true. This is why 2 Corinthians 10:18 says, "He is approved whom God commends."

Reply to objection 1: The Apostle is speaking here of the glory that comes from God in the

presence of His angels and not about the glory that comes from men. Hence, Mark 8:38 [cf. Luke 12:8] says, “The Son of Man will acknowledge him in the glory of His Father in the presence of His angels.”

Reply to objection 2: The good of a man that exists in the cognition of the multitude through fame or glory must—if the cognition is indeed true—be derived from a good that exists within the man himself, and so it presupposes either perfect or inchoative beatitude.

On the other hand, if the cognition is false, then it does not agree with reality, and so there is no good that is found in him by reason of his popular acclaim (*cuius fama celebris habetur*).

Hence, it is clear that there is no way in which fame can make a man blessed (*beatum*).

Reply to objection 3: Fame lacks stability and is, in fact, easily destroyed by false rumors. And if it does at times persevere in a stable manner, this is incidental. By contrast, beatitude has stability in its own right and forever (*habet stabilitatem per se et semper*).

Article 4

Does man’s beatitude lie in power?

It seems that [man’s] beatitude lies in power:

Objection 1: All things tend toward being similar to God (*appetunt assimilari Deo*) insofar as He is their ultimate end and their first principle. But powerful men, because of the likeness of their power, seem to be especially conformed to God. Hence, they are called ‘gods’ even in Scripture, as is clear from Exodus 22:28 (“You shall not speak ill of the gods”). Therefore, beatitude lies in power.

Objection 2: Beatitude is a perfect good. But it is most perfect for a man to be able to rule others as well—a function that belongs to those who have been established in power. Therefore, beatitude lies in power.

Objection 3: Since beatitude is maximally desirable, what is opposed to it is by all means to be avoided. But what men especially flee from is servitude, which is counterposed to power. Therefore, beatitude lies in power.

But contrary to this: Beatitude is a perfect good. But power is especially imperfect. For as Boethius says in *De Consolatione Philosophiae* 3, “A man’s power cannot expel the bites of care or avoid the prickles of dread.” And later he adds, “Do you think a man is powerful when he is surrounded by men who are afraid of him but whom he himself fears even more?” Therefore, beatitude does not lie in power.

I respond: It is impossible for beatitude to lie in power, and this for two reasons:

First, as is clear from *Metaphysics* 5, power has the character of a principle, whereas beatitude has the character of an ultimate end.

Second, power is open both to what is good and to what is evil (*potestas se habet ad bonum et ad malum*), whereas beatitude is man’s proper and perfect good. Hence, some sort of beatitude would be more able to lie in the *good use* of power, which occurs through virtue, than in power itself.

Moreover, there are four general arguments that can be adduced to show that beatitude does not lie in any of the exterior goods discussed thus far:

The first of these arguments is that since beatitude is a man’s highest good, it is incompatible with any sort of evil. But all of the goods discussed thus far are found both in good men and in bad men.

The second argument is that since, as is clear from *Ethics* 1, beatitude is sufficient by its very nature (*per se sufficiens*), it must be the case that once beatitude is attained, no good which is necessary for a man is lacking. But after each of the goods discussed thus far has been attained, there are still many goods lacking that are necessary for a man, e.g., wisdom, bodily health, and others of this sort.

The third argument is that since beatitude is a perfect good, no evil can come to anyone because

of beatitude. But this does not apply to the goods discussed thus far; for Ecclesiastes 5:12 says that riches are sometimes kept “to the detriment of their owner.” And the same thing is obvious in the case of the other three goods.

The fourth argument is that a man is ordered toward beatitude by interior principles, since he is naturally ordered toward it. But the four goods discussed thus far come from exterior causes, and very often from fortune. This is why they are called ‘goods of fortune’.

Hence, it is clear that beatitude cannot in any way lie in the goods discussed thus far.

Reply to objection 1: God’s power is His goodness, and so He can use His power only in the right way (*non nisi bene*). But the same does not hold in the case of men. Hence, it is not enough for a man’s beatitude that he become similar to God with respect to power, unless he also becomes similar to Him with respect to goodness.

Reply to objection 2: Just as the best situation is for someone to use his power well in ruling a multitude, so the worst situation is for him is to use his power badly. And so power is open both to good and to evil.

Reply to objection 3: Servitude is an obstacle to the good use of power. This is why men naturally avoid it—and not because man’s highest good lies in power.

Article 5

Does man’s beatitude lie in any bodily good?

It seems that man’s beatitude lies in some bodily good:

Objection 1: Ecclesiasticus 30:16 says, “There are no riches above the riches of the health of the body.” But beatitude lies in what is the best. Therefore, it lies in the health of the body.

Objection 2: In *De Divinis Nominibus*, chap. 5, Dionysius says that to exist (*esse*) is better than to live (*vivere*), and to live is better than the other things that follow upon it. But a man needs bodily health in order to exist and to live. Therefore, since beatitude is man’s highest good, it seems that bodily health is especially pertinent to beatitude.

Objection 3: The more general (*communius*) something is, the higher the principle it depends upon, since the higher a cause is, the more things its power extends to. But just as an efficient cause’s causality is thought of as having to do with an inflowing (*secundum influentiam*), so an end’s causality has to do with an appetite (*secundum appetitum*). Therefore, just as the first efficient cause is a cause that flows into all things (*influit in omnia*), so an ultimate end is a cause that is sought after by all things (*desideratur ab omnibus*). But existence itself (*ipsum esse*) is what is most sought after by all things. Therefore, man’s beatitude consists especially in those things that pertain to his existence, e.g., bodily health.

But contrary to this: With respect to beatitude, man is more excellent than all the other animals. But with respect to bodily goods, he is surpassed by many animals; for instance, he is surpassed by the elephant in length of life, by the lion in strength, and by the deer in speed. Therefore, man’s beatitude does not lie in bodily goods.

I respond: There are two reasons why it is impossible for man’s beatitude to lie in bodily goods:

First, it is impossible for the ultimate end of a thing that is ordered toward something else as an end to be the conservation of that same thing in existence (*in esse*). Thus, a ship’s captain (*gubernator*) does not intend as an ultimate end the preservation of the ship that has been entrusted to him; for the ship is ordered toward something else as an end, viz., toward sailing. Now just as a ship is entrusted to the captain to direct, so man is entrusted to his own will and reason—this according to Ecclesiasticus 15:14 (“God made man from the beginning, and left him in the hand of his own counsel”). But it is obvious

that man is ordered toward something else as his end, given that man is not the highest good. Hence, it is impossible for the ultimate end of human reason and will to be the conservation of human existence (*conservatio humani esse*).

Second, even if it were granted that the end of human reason and will is the conservation of human existence, it would still not be possible to claim that man's end is a bodily good. For human existence lies in the soul and the body. And, as was shown above (*ST* 1, q. 75, a. 2), even though the body's existence depends on the soul, the human soul's existence does not depend on the body; and the body itself exists for the sake of the soul in the way that matter exists for the sake of form and in the way that instruments exist for the sake of the mover, in order that the mover might exercise its actions through them. Hence all bodily goods are ordered toward the goods of the soul as toward their end. Hence, it is impossible for beatitude, which is the ultimate end, to lie in the goods of the body.

Reply to objection 1: Just as the body is ordered toward the soul as its end, so exterior goods are ordered toward the body itself. And so it is reasonable to prefer the good of the body to exterior goods, which are signified in this passage by "riches"—just as it is reasonable to prefer the good of the soul to all the goods of the body.

Reply to objection 2: Existence (*esse*) taken absolutely—i.e., insofar as it includes within itself all the perfection of being—surpasses life and all the goods that follow upon it, since existence (*esse*) in this sense contains within itself all the ensuing goods (*sic ipsum esse prae habet in se omnia subsequencia*). And it is in this sense that Dionysius is speaking.

However, if *esse* itself is thought of as participating in this or in that thing, where these things do not capture the whole perfection of being (*non capiunt totam perfectionem essendi*) but instead have imperfect existence (*esse*), viz., the existence (*esse*) of some creature, then it is clear that existence (*esse*) itself in this sense is more eminent when taken with an added perfection. Hence, Dionysius himself says in the same place that living things are better than [merely] existing things, and intelligent things are better than [merely] living things.

Reply to objection 3: Given that the end corresponds to the principle, this argument proves that the ultimate end is the first principle of being, in whom exists every perfection of being and whose likeness [all things] seek in due proportion—some with respect just to *esse*; some with respect to living-*esse*; and some, a few, with respect to living-*esse* and intelligent-*esse* and beatified-*esse*.

Article 6

Does man's beatitude lie in delight or pleasure?

It seems that man's beatitude lies in delight (*delectatio*) or pleasure (*voluptas*):

Objection 1: Since beatitude is the ultimate end, it is not desired for the sake of anything else; instead, other things are desired for its sake. But this feature seems especially to belong to delight (*delectatio*); for, as *Ethics* 10 points out, "it is ridiculous to ask someone why he wants to be delighted (*propter quid velit delectari*).” Therefore, beatitude consists especially in pleasure and delight.

Objection 2: As the *Liber de Causis* says, "a first cause makes a stronger impression than a secondary cause." But the end's influence has to do with the desire for it. Therefore, that which especially moves one's appetite seems especially to have the character of an ultimate end. But this is pleasure (*voluptas*). An indication of this is that pleasure (*delectatio*) absorbs a man's will and reason to such an extent that it makes him disdain other goods. Therefore, it seems that the ultimate end, which is beatitude, consists especially in pleasure (*in voluptate*).

Objection 3: Since desire is for the good, that which all things desire seems to be the best thing. But all things desire delight (*delectatio*)—both the wise and the foolish, and even things that lack reason.

Therefore, delight (*delectatio*) is the best thing. Therefore, beatitude, which is the highest good, lies in pleasure (*voluptas*).

But contrary to this: In *De Consolatione Philosophiae* 3 Boethius says, “Anyone who chooses to look back on his past excesses will understand that pleasures have a sad ending. And if pleasures can make a men blessed, there is no reason not to say that even brute animals are blessed.”

I respond: As *Ethics* 3 says, “Because corporeal delights (*delectationes corporales*) are known to more people, they have taken the name ‘pleasures’ (*voluptates*) for themselves”—even though there are other, more powerful, delights. Nevertheless, beatitude does not principally lie in them.

For within each thing, what pertains to its essence is different from its proper accidents; for instance, in the case of man, his being a rational mortal animal is different from his being capable of laughing. Thus, one should notice that every delight is a sort of proper accident which follows upon beatitude or upon some part of beatitude. For someone delights in having a good which befits him—regardless of whether he has it in reality, or in his hopes, or at least in his memories. Now if the fitting good in question is a perfect good, then it is human beatitude itself, whereas if it is an imperfect good, then it is a certain participation in beatitude—either a proximate participation, or a remote one, or at least an apparent one. Hence, it is clear that not even the very delight which follows upon the perfect good is itself the essence of beatitude; instead, it is a certain consequence of beatitude, like a *per se* accident.

Moreover, corporeal pleasure cannot follow upon the perfect good even in the way just explained. For corporeal pleasure follows upon a good that is apprehended by the sensory power, which is a power of the soul insofar as it uses the body. But the good which pertains to the body and which is apprehended by the sensory power cannot be man’s perfect good. For since the rational soul exceeds the measure of corporeal matter, the part of the soul that is unrestricted by a corporeal organ (*ab organo corporeo absoluta*) has a sort of unlimitedness (*quaedam infinitas*) with respect to the body and with respect to the parts of the soul that are concretized with the body (*partium animae corpori concretarum*)—in the way that immaterial things are in a sense unlimited (*infinita*) in relation to material things by reason of the fact that form is in some sense contracted to and limited by matter. Thus, a form that is free of matter is in some sense unlimited (*infinita*). And so the sensory power, which is a corporeal power, has cognition of the singular, which is made determinate by matter, whereas the intellect, which is a power free of matter, has cognition of the universal, which is abstracted from matter and contains infinitely many singulars within itself. Hence, it is clear that a good which befits the body and which causes corporeal delight through the sensory power’s apprehension is not man’s perfect good, but is, as it were, minimal in comparison to the good of the soul. Hence, Wisdom 7:9 says, “All gold, in comparison to wisdom, is as a little sand.” So, then, corporeal pleasure is neither beatitude itself nor a *per se* accident of beatitude.

Reply to objection 1: The reason why delight is desired is the same as the reason why beatitude is desired—and this is nothing other than the repose of desire in the good (*quietatio appetitus in bono*). Similarly, the natural power by which a heavy thing is borne downward is the same as the power by which it comes to rest there. Hence, just as the good is desired for its own sake, so too delight is desired for its own sake and not for the sake of something else, if ‘for the sake of’ is expressing a final cause. However, if it is instead expressing a formal cause or, better, an efficient cause (*causam motivam*), then in that sense delight is desirable for the sake of something else, viz., for the sake of the good which is the object of delight and which, as a result, is its principle and gives it its form. For the reason why delight is sought after is that it is repose in a good that is desired.

Reply to objection 2: The strong desire for sensible delight occurs because the operations of the sensory power, since they are the beginnings of our cognition (*principia nostrae cognitionis*), are more perceptible. Hence, sensible delights are also desired by more people.

Reply to objection 3: All men desire delight in the same way that they desire the good. Yet, as has been explained, they desire delight by reason of the good, and not vice versa. Hence, it does not

follow that delight is the greatest good in its own right (*maximum et per se bonum*). Rather, each delight follows upon some good, and there is a delight that follows upon that which is the greatest good in its own right.

Article 7

Does man's beatitude lie in a good of the soul?

It seems that beatitude lies in a good of the soul:

Objection 1: Beatitude is a certain human good. But man's good is divided into three, viz., exterior goods, goods of the body, and goods of the soul. But as has been shown above (aa. 4-5), beatitude does not lie in the exterior goods or in the goods of the body. Therefore, it lies in the goods of the soul.

Objection 2: The one for whom we desire a good is such that we love him more than the good we desire for him; for instance, we love the friend for whom we desire money more than the money. But each individual desires every good for himself. Therefore, he loves himself more than all other goods. But beatitude is what he especially loves; this is obvious from the fact that all other goods are loved and desired for its sake. Therefore, beatitude lies in some good that belongs to the man himself. But it does not lie in the goods of the body. Therefore, it lies in the goods of the soul.

Objection 3: Perfection is something that belongs to what is perfected. But beatitude is a certain perfection of a man. Therefore, beatitude is something that belongs to the man. But as has been shown, it is not something that belongs to the body. And so it lies in the goods of the soul.

But contrary to this: In *De Doctrina Christiana* Augustine says, "That in which the good life is constituted is to be loved for its own sake." But a man is not to be loved for his own sake; instead, whatever exists in a man is to be loved for the sake of God. Therefore, beatitude does not lie in any good of the soul.

I respond: As was explained above (q. 1, a. 8), 'end' has two senses, viz., (a) *the thing itself* that we desire to obtain, and (b) the *having*, i.e., the attaining or the possessing, of that thing (*usus seu adeptio aut possessio illius rei*).

Thus, if we are talking about man's ultimate end *as regards the thing itself* which we desire as our ultimate end, then it is impossible for man's ultimate end to be either the soul itself or anything that belongs to the soul.

For the soul, taken in itself, is like something that exists in potentiality, since it comes to be actually knowing from having been knowing in potentiality, and it becomes actually virtuous from having been virtuous in potentiality. But since the potentiality is for the sake of the actuality in the sense of being for the sake of what completes it, it is impossible that what is in potentiality in its own right should have the nature of an ultimate end. Hence, it is impossible for the soul itself to be its own ultimate end.

The same holds for anything that belongs to the soul, whether it be a power, a habit, or an act. For the good that is the ultimate end is a perfect good that satisfies the appetite (*bonum perfectum complens appetitum*). Now man's appetite, which is his will, is for a *universal* good. But any good that inheres in the soul itself is a participated good and, as a result, a *particularized* good. Hence, it is impossible that any of these goods should be man's ultimate end.

On the other hand, if we are talking about man's ultimate end *as regards the attaining or possessing of it*, i.e., as regards any sort of having of the very thing that is desired as an end, then something that belongs to a man's soul is pertinent to the ultimate end. For a man attains beatitude *through* his soul (*per animam*).

Therefore, the very thing that is desired as the end is what beatitude *lies in* and what *makes one blessed*, but it is the *attainment of that thing* which is called *beatitude*. Hence, one should say that

beatitude is something that belongs to the soul, but that what beatitude lies in is something outside of the soul.

Reply to objection 1: Insofar as the division in question includes all the goods that are desirable to a man, what is called ‘a good of the soul’ includes not only [the soul’s] powers, habits, and acts, but also its objects, which are extrinsic to it. And in this sense there is nothing to prevent one from saying that what beatitude lies in is a certain good of the soul.

Reply to objection 2: As regards what is proposed here, the relevant point is that beatitude is especially loved as a *desired good* (*bonum concupitum*), whereas a friend is loved as the *one for whom* the good is desired; and in this latter sense a man loves himself as well. Hence, the character of the love is not the same in the two cases.

Now when we treat charity below (*ST* 2-2, q. 26), there will be room to consider the question of whether a man might love something above himself (*supra se*) with a love of friendship.

Reply to objection 3: Since beatitude itself is a perfection of the soul, it is a certain good that inheres in the soul. But as has been explained, what beatitude lies in, i.e., what makes one blessed, is something outside the soul.

Article 8

Does man’s beatitude lie in a created good?

It seems that man’s beatitude lies in some created good:

Objection 1: In *De Divinis Nominibus*, chap. 7, Dionysius says that God’s wisdom “joins the ends of the first things to the principles of the secondary things.” This can be taken to mean that the high point for a lower nature is to attain the low point of a higher nature. But man’s highest good is beatitude. Therefore, since, as was established in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 111, a. 1), an angel is higher than a man in the order of nature, a man’s beatitude seems to lie in his attaining in some way the status of an angel (*aliquo modo attingit ad angelum*).

Objection 2: The ultimate end of a thing lies in what is complete in relation to it (*in suo perfecto*); hence, a part exists for the sake of the whole as its end. But the whole universe of creatures, which is called the ‘greater world’, is related to a man, who in *Physics* 7 is called a ‘lesser world’, in the same way that what is complete is related to what is incomplete (*sicut perfectum ad imperfectum*). Therefore, man’s beatitude lies in the whole universe of creatures.

Objection 3: A man is made blessed (*beatus*) by the fact that his natural desire comes to rest. But man’s natural desire does not extend to a greater good than he himself is able to take possession of. Therefore, since man is not capable of a good that exceeds the limits of all of creation (*limites totius creaturae*), it seems that man can be made blessed by some created good. And so man’s beatitude lies in some created good.

But contrary to this: In *De Civitate Dei* 19 Augustine says, “Just as the soul is the life of the flesh, so God is man’s blessed life (*beata vita*)—God, of whom it is said, ‘Blessed the people whose God is the Lord’ (Psalm 143:15).”

I respond: It is impossible for man’s beatitude to lie in any created good. For beatitude is a perfect good that puts the appetite totally to rest—it would not be the ultimate end otherwise, i.e., if something remained to be desired. But the object of the will, which is man’s appetite, is the universal good, just as the object of the intellect is universal truth. From this it is clear that nothing can put man’s will to rest except the universal good. But the universal good is found only in God and not in any created good, since every creature has participated goodness. Hence, only God can satisfy man’s will—this according to Psalm 102:5 (“He satisfies your desire with good things”). Therefore, it is in God alone that man’s beatitude lies.

Reply to objection 1: The high point of man does indeed attain to the low point of angelic nature by a sort of likeness. Yet man does not rest there as in his ultimate end. Instead, he gets all the way to the universal source itself of goodness, i.e., to Him who is the universal object of beatitude for all the blessed insofar as He is the infinite and perfect good.

Reply to objection 2: If a given whole is not the ultimate end but is instead ordered toward a further end, then the ultimate end of a part of it is not the whole itself but something else. Now the universe of creatures, to which man is related as a part to a whole, is not the ultimate end. Instead, it is ordered toward God as its ultimate end. Hence, it is God Himself, and not the good of the universe, that is man's ultimate end.

Reply to objection 3: There is a created good, in the sense of something *intrinsic to and inherent in* man, that is not less than the good that man is capable of. Nevertheless, this created good is indeed less than some good, in the sense of an *object*, which man is capable of and which is infinite. Moreover, the participated good of an angel, or of the whole universe, is a finite and contracted good.

QUESTION 3

What Beatitude Is

Next we have to consider what beatitude is (question 3) and what is required for it (question 4).

On the first topic there are eight questions: (1) Is beatitude something uncreated? (2) If it is something created, is it an operation [i.e., an action]? (3) Is it an operation of the sentient part of the soul or of the intellective part? (4) If it is an operation of the intellective part of the soul, is it an operation of the intellect or of the will? (5) If it is an operation of the intellect, is it an operation of the speculative intellect or of the practical intellect? (6) If it is an operation of the speculative intellect, does it consist in a speculative act belonging to the speculative sciences? (7) Does it consist in a speculative act with respect to the separated substances, i.e., the angels? (8) Does it consist solely in a speculative act with respect to God by which He is seen through His essence?

Article 1

Is beatitude something uncreated?

It seems that beatitude is something uncreated:

Objection 1: In *De Consolatione Philosophiae* 3 Boethius says, “It is necessary to confess that God is beatitude itself.”

Objection 2: Beatitude is the highest good. But it belongs to God to be the highest good. Therefore, since there is no more than one highest good, it seems that beatitude is identical with God.

Objection 3: Beatitude is the ultimate end toward which the human will naturally tends. But the will ought to tend toward nothing other than God as an end. “He alone is to be enjoyed (*quo solo fruendum est*),” as Augustine puts it.

But contrary to this: Nothing that is made is uncreated. But man’s beatitude is something made, since, according to Augustine in *De Doctrina Christiana* 1, “Those things are to be enjoyed which make us blessed.” Therefore, beatitude is not something uncreated.

I respond: As was explained above (q. 1, a. 8 and q. 2, a. 7), ‘end’ has two senses: (a) *the thing itself* which we desire to attain, in the sense that *money* is an end to the avaricious man; and (b) attaining (*adeptio*) or possessing (*possessio*), i.e., having (*usus*) or enjoying (*fruitio*), that thing which is desired, in the sense that *having money* is said to be the avaricious man’s end, and *enjoying a pleasurable thing* is said to be the intemperate man’s end.

Therefore, in the first sense, man’s ultimate end is an uncreated good, viz., God, who alone is able to satisfy man’s will perfectly by His infinite goodness. But in the second sense, man’s ultimate end is something created which exists within him and which is nothing other than possessing or enjoying the ultimate end (cf. *ST* 1, q. 12, a. 5).

Therefore, if man’s beatitude is thought of with respect to its *cause or object*, then in this sense it is something uncreated, whereas if it is thought of with respect to the *very essence of beatitude*, then in this sense it is something created.

Reply to objection 1: God is beatitude through His essence, since He is blessed through His own essence and not by attaining, or participating in, something else. By contrast, as Boethius says in the same place, men are blessed through participation, just as they are said to be ‘gods’ through participation. And the participation in beatitude by virtue of which a man is called blessed is itself something created.

Reply to objection 2: The reason why beatitude is said to be man’s highest good is that it is an act of attaining or enjoying the highest good (*est adeptio vel fruitio summi boni*).

Reply to objection 3: Beatitude is called the ultimate end in the sense in which attaining an end is called the end.

Article 2

Is beatitude an operation [i.e., an action]?

It seems that beatitude is not an operation [or action]:

Objection 1: In Romans 6:22 the Apostle says, “You have your fruit unto sanctification, and as your end, life eternal.” But life is the very existence (*esse*) of living things and not an operation. Therefore, the ultimate end, i.e., beatitude, is not an operation.

Objection 2: In *De Consolatione Philosophiae* 3 Boethius says that beatitude is “a state made perfect by the aggregation of all goods.” But ‘state’ does not designate an operation. Therefore, beatitude is not an operation.

Objection 3: ‘Beatitude’ signifies something that exists within the one who is blessed, since it is a man’s ultimate perfection. But ‘operation’ does not signify a thing as *existing within* the one who operates; rather, it signifies it as *proceeding from* the one who operates. Therefore, beatitude is not an operation.

Objection 4: Beatitude remains permanently in the one who is blessed. But an operation is temporary and does not remain permanently (*non permanet sed transit*). Therefore, beatitude is not an operation.

Objection 5: A single beatitude belongs to a single man. But operations are multiple. Therefore, beatitude is not an operation.

Objection 6: Beatitude exists without interruption in the one who is blessed. But human operations are frequently interrupted, e.g., by sleep, or by some other occupation, or by rest. Therefore, beatitude is not an operation.

But contrary to this: In *Ethics* 1 the Philosopher says, “Happiness (*felicitas*) is an operation in accord with perfect virtue.”

I respond: In the sense in which a man’s beatitude is something created existing within him, one must claim that man’s beatitude is an operation.

For beatitude is a man’s ultimate perfection. But each thing is perfect to the extent that it is actual, since a potentiality is unperfected (*imperfecta*) in the absence of its [corresponding] actuality. Therefore, beatitude must consist in man’s ultimate actuality. But it is clear that an operation is the ultimate actuality of a thing that operates; this is why the operation is called “*second actuality*” by the Philosopher in *De Anima* 2. For it can be the case that what possesses a form is operating [only] in potentiality, in the way that someone who has knowledge might be thinking [only] in potentiality. Hence, in the case of other entities as well, each thing is said to exist *for the sake of* its operation, as *De Caelo* 2 says. Therefore, it must be the case that man’s beatitude is an operation.

Reply to objection 1: ‘Life’ has two senses.

In the first sense, what is called ‘life’ is the very existence (*esse*) of the living thing. In this sense, beatitude is not life. For it has been shown (q. 2, a. 5) that man’s *esse*, whatever it might be, is not man’s beatitude, since it is only God who is such that His beatitude is His *esse*.

In the second sense, what is called ‘life’ is an operation of a living thing by which a principle of life is made actual. It is in this sense that we talk about ‘the active life’ or ‘the contemplative life’ or ‘the pleasure-seeking life’. This is the sense in which the ultimate end is called ‘eternal life’. This is clear from what is said in John 17:3: “This is eternal life: that they may know you, the one true God.”

Reply to objection 2: In defining beatitude Boethius was thinking about the *general concept* of beatitude (*ipsam communem beatitudinis rationem*). For the general concept of beatitude is that it is a general and perfect good (*bonum commune perfectum*). And this is what he meant when he said that beatitude is “a state made perfect by the aggregation of all goods”—which means nothing other than that one who is blessed is in a state of the perfect good (*in statu boni perfecti*).

Aristotle, on the other hand, expressed the very *essence* of beatitude when he showed what it is through which a man is in such a state, viz., through a certain operation. And in *Ethics* 1 he himself also showed that beatitude is a perfect good.

Reply to objection 3: As *Metaphysics* 9 says, there are two sorts of actions.

The first sort, e.g., burning or cutting, proceeds from the thing that is operating into an exterior matter. Beatitude cannot be this sort of action, since, as it says in the same place, such an operation is more the action and perfection of the patient and not of the agent.

The second sort of action, e.g., sensing, intellectual understanding, or willing, is an action that remains within the agent itself. This sort of action is a perfection and act of the agent. This is the sort of operation that it is possible for beatitude to be.

Reply to objection 4: Since ‘beatitude’ expresses a certain ultimate perfection, ‘beatitude’ must have different senses because the diverse things capable of beatitude are able to attain diverse grades of perfection.

For instance, in God there is beatitude through His essence, since His very *esse* is His operation—an operation by which He has enjoyment of Himself and not of anything else.

On the other hand, in the beatified angels there is ultimate perfection through an operation by which they are joined to the uncreated good. And this operation is a single everlasting operation in them.

By contrast, in men who are in the state of the present life, the ultimate perfection is through an operation by which a man is joined to God, but this operation cannot be continuous and, as a result, it cannot be a single operation, either, since an operation is multiplied by being divided. For this reason, in the state of the present life a man cannot have perfect beatitude. Hence, in *Ethics* 1 the Philosopher, in positing beatitude for man in this life, says that it is imperfect, and after much discussion he concludes that “we call men blessed, but as men.”

However, God has promised us perfect beatitude, when we will be “like the angels in heaven,” as Matthew 22:30 says. Therefore, when applied to this perfect beatitude, the objection loses its force. For in this state of beatitude man’s mind will be joined to God by a single operation that is continuous and everlasting.

By contrast, in the present life we fall short of perfect beatitude to the extent that we fall short of the oneness and continuity of such an operation. Yet there is some participation in beatitude, and this participation is greater to the extent that the operation is able to be more continuous and unified. And so in the *active life*, which is occupied with many things, there is less of the character of beatitude than there is in the *contemplative life*, which is centered on one thing, viz., the contemplation of truth. And even if at times the man is not actually engaging in the sort of operation in question, still, because he is always ready to engage in it, and because he orders even the very cessation of the operation, e.g., sleep or some natural occupation, toward the operation in question, the operation seems like it is continuous.

Reply to objection 5 and objection 6: The replies to the fifth and sixth objections are clear from what has just been said.

Article 3

Does beatitude consist in an operation of the sentient part of the soul or only in an operation of the intellective part?

It seems that beatitude consists in an operation of the sentient part of the soul as well [as in an operation of the intellective part]:

Objection 1: Outside of an intellective operation, there is no operation in man more noble than a sentient operation. But in us an intellective operation depends on a sentient operation, since, as *De*

Anima 3 says, “we are unable to have intellectual understanding without a phantasm.” Therefore, beatitude consists in a sentient operation as well.

Objection 2: In *De Consolatione Philosophiae* 3 Boethius says that beatitude is “a state made perfect by the aggregation of all goods.” But some goods are sensible goods, which we attain through the operation of the sensory power. Therefore, it seems that an operation of the sensory power is required for beatitude.

Objection 3: As is proved in *Ethics* 1, beatitude is a perfect good—which would not be the case if a man were not perfected by it with respect to all of his parts. But certain parts of the soul are perfected through sentient operations. Therefore, a sentient operation is required for beatitude.

But contrary to this: Sentient operations are common both to us and to brute animals, but beatitude is not common to us and to brute animals. Therefore, beatitude does not consist in a sentient operation.

I respond: There are three ways in which something can pertain to beatitude: (a) *essentially* (*essentialiter*), (b) *as an antecedent* (*antecedenter*), and (c) *as a consequence* (*consequenter*).

No operation of the sensory power can pertain *essentially* to beatitude. For man’s beatitude consists essentially in his being joined to an uncreated good, which, as was shown above (a. 1 and q. 2, a. 8), is the ultimate end and such that a man cannot be joined to it through an operation of the sensory power. Similarly, as has been shown (q. 2, a. 5), man’s beatitude does not lie in corporeal goods, which are all that we attain to through the operation of the sensory power.

However, the operations of the sensory power can pertain to beatitude both *as an antecedent* and *as a consequence*:

They pertain *as an antecedent* to the sort of imperfect beatitude that can be had in the present life. For the operation of the intellect has as a prerequisite (*praeexigit*) the operation of the sensory power.

They pertain *as a consequence* to the perfect beatitude that we await in heaven, because, after the resurrection, as Augustine says in his letter *Ad Dioscorum*, “from the very beatitude of the soul there will be a certain overflow (*refluentia*) into the body and into the bodily senses, in order that they might be perfected in their operations.” This will become clearer below, when we talk about the resurrection. However, the operation by which the human mind is joined to God will not in that state (*tunc*) depend on the sensory power.

Reply to objection 1: This objection proves that the operation of the sensory power is required as an antecedent for the sort of imperfect beatitude that can be had in this life.

Reply to objection 2: The sort of perfect beatitude that an angel has is such that it is an “aggregation of all goods” through his being joined to the font of all good—and not such that it requires every single particular good (*non quod indigeat singulis particularibus bonis*).

By contrast, in the imperfect beatitude of the present life (*in hac beatitudine imperfecta*), what is required is an aggregation of goods that are sufficient for the most perfect operation possible in this life.

Reply to objection 3: In perfect beatitude the whole man is perfected, but he is perfected in his lower part through an overflow (*per redundantiā*) from his higher part. By contrast, in the imperfect beatitude of the present life, it goes, conversely, from the perfection of the lower part to the perfection of the higher part.

Article 4

Does beatitude consist in an act of the will?

It seems that beatitude consists in an act of the will:

Objection 1: In *De Civitate Dei* 19 Augustine says that man’s beatitude lies in peace; hence,

Psalm 147:3 says, “He has placed peace within your borders.” But peace has to do with the will. Therefore, man’s beatitude consists in an act of will (*in voluntate*).

Objection 2: Beatitude is the highest good. But the good is the object of the will. Therefore, beatitude consists in an operation of the will.

Objection 3: The ultimate end corresponds to the first mover, in the way that the ultimate end of the army as a whole is victory, which is the end of the leader who moves everyone. But the first mover in the case of an operation is the will, since, as will be explained below (q. 9, a. 1), the will moves the other powers. Therefore, beatitude has to do with the will.

Objection 4: If beatitude is an operation, it must be man’s most noble operation. But as is clear from the Apostle in 1 Corinthians 13, loving God (*dilectio Dei*), which is an act of the will, is a more noble operation than knowing God (*cognitio Dei*), which is an operation of the intellect. Therefore, it seems that beatitude consists in an act of the will.

Objection 5: In *De Trinitate* 13 Augustine says, “The blessed man is such that (a) he has everything that he wills and (b) he wills nothing badly.” And a little later he adds, “Someone is close to being blessed if he wills well whatever he wills. For good things make him blessed, and he already has something of those goods, viz., a good will itself.” Therefore, beatitude consists in an act of the will.

But contrary to this: In John 17:3 our Lord says, “This is eternal life: that they know you, the one true God.” But as has been explained (a. 2), eternal life is the ultimate end. Therefore, man’s beatitude consists in a cognition of God, and this is an act of the intellect.

I respond: As was explained above (q. 2, a. 6), two things are required for beatitude: (a) the *essence* of beatitude and (b) its *per se accident*, as it were, viz., the delight adjoined to it.

Thus, I claim that as regards what beatitude is in its essence (*essentialiter*), it is impossible for it to consist in an act of the will. For it is clear from what was said above (aa. 1-2 and q. 2, a. 7) that beatitude is the attainment of the ultimate end. But attaining an end does not consist in an act of the will. For the will is directed toward the end—an *absent* end when the will *desires* it, and a *present* end when it *delights* while reposing in it. But it is clear that an act of desiring an end (*desiderium finis*) is not itself an act of attaining the end (*ipsum desiderium finis non est consecutio finis*); rather, it is a movement toward the end. Moreover, an act of delighting comes to the will because the end is present, whereas it is not the case, conversely, that something is present because the will delights in it. Therefore, there must be something other than the act of the will (*oportet aliquid aliud esse quam actum voluntatis*) such that through it the end itself becomes present to the one who wills.

This is manifestly obvious in the case of sensible ends. For if acquiring money (*consequi pecuniam*) occurred through an act of the will, then the covetous man would acquire the money right from the start, when he willed to have it. But, of course, it is absent from him at the beginning, and he acquires it by taking it with his hand or in some other such way; and it is *then* that he delights in the money now possessed.

Therefore, the same thing happens with an intelligible end, too. For at the beginning we will to attain some intelligible end. But we attain it by the fact that it becomes present to us through an act of the intellect. And then our delighted will comes to rest in the end now attained.

So, then, the essence of beatitude consists in an act of the intellect, whereas what pertains to the will is an act of delighting that is consequent to this beatitude. Accordingly, in *Confessiones* 10 Augustine says that beatitude is “rejoicing in the truth” (*gaudium de veritate*), because the act of rejoicing is the consummation of beatitude.

Reply to objection 1: Peace is relevant to man’s ultimate end not in the sense that it is beatitude itself in its essence, but in the sense that it is related to beatitude as an antecedent and as a consequence. *As an antecedent*, to the extent that all the troubles or obstacles (*perturbantia et impediencia*) associated with the ultimate end have already been removed; *as a consequence*, to the extent that a man, having attained his ultimate end, remains at peace (*remanet pacatus*) now that his desire has been put to rest.

Reply to objection 2: The will's first object is not its own act—just as the first object of the power of sight is not the act of seeing itself, but the visible thing. Hence, from the very fact that beatitude is the will's first object it follows that beatitude is not the will's very act.

Reply to objection 3: It is the intellect, rather than the will, that first apprehends an end, whereas the movement toward the end begins in the will. And so what is due to the will is what ultimately follows upon the attainment of the end, viz., an act of delighting or enjoying (*delectation vel fruitio*).

Reply to objection 4: Loving (*dilectio*) is preeminent over knowing (*cognitio*) as far as effecting movement [toward the end] is concerned, but knowing precedes loving in the attainment [of the end]. For as Augustine says in *De Trinitate* 10, "A thing is not loved unless it is known." And so we first attain an intelligible end through an action of the intellect, just as we first attain a sensible end through an action of the sensory power.

Reply to objection 5: He who has everything that he wills is blessed because he *has* the things that he wills—and this having is through something other than an act of the will.

On the other hand, to will nothing badly is a requirement for beatitude in the sense of being an appropriate disposition (*debita dispositio*) for beatitude.

Now a good will counts as one of the goods that make a man blessed insofar as it is a certain inclination in the will [toward beatitude]—just as a movement is assigned to the genus of its terminus, as, e.g., an alteration is assigned to the genus *quality*.

Article 5

Does beatitude consist in an operation of the speculative intellect or of the practical intellect?

It seems that beatitude consists in an operation of the practical intellect:

Objection 1: The ultimate end of any creature consists in its becoming similar to God (*in assimilationem ad Deum*). But man is more similar to God through his practical intellect, which is a cause of things that are understood intellectually, than through his speculative intellect, whose knowledge is taken from the things. Therefore, man's beatitude consists in an operation of the practical intellect rather than in an operation of the speculative intellect.

Objection 2: Beatitude is man's perfect good. But the practical intellect is more ordered toward the good than is the speculative intellect, which is ordered toward the true. Hence, it is because of the perfection of the practical intellect that we are called 'good', and not because of the perfection of the speculative intellect. Rather, we are called 'knowledgeable' or 'intelligent' because of the perfection of the speculative intellect. Therefore, man's beatitude consists in an act of the practical intellect rather than in an act of the speculative intellect.

Objection 3: Beatitude is a certain good that belongs to a man himself. But the speculative intellect is occupied more with things that lie outside of a man, whereas the practical intellect is occupied with things that belong to the man himself, such as his operations and his passions. Therefore, man's beatitude consists in an operation of the practical intellect rather than in an operation of the speculative intellect.

But contrary to this: In *De Trinitate* 1 Augustine says, "Contemplation is promised to us as the end of all our actions and the eternal perfection of our joys."

I respond: Beatitude consists in an operation of the speculative intellect rather than in an operation of the practical intellect. This is clear from three considerations:

First, if man's beatitude is an operation, it must be man's best operation. But man's best operation is the operation that belongs to the best power with respect to the best object. Now the best power is the intellect and its best object is the divine good, which is an object of the speculative intellect and not of

the practical intellect. Hence, beatitude consists especially in this operation, i.e., in an act of contemplating divine things (*in contemplatione divinorum*). And since, as *Ethics* 9 and 10 say, “Each thing seems to be that which is best in it,” this operation is especially proper to man and especially delightful to him.

The same point is clear from the fact that contemplation is especially sought after for its own sake. By contrast, an act of the practical intellect is sought after not for its own sake, but for the sake of an action. And the actions themselves are likewise ordered toward some end. This is why it is clear that the ultimate end cannot consist in the active life, which is associated with the practical intellect.

Third, the same point is clear from the fact that the contemplative life is common to both man and higher beings, viz., God and the angels, to whom man is assimilated through beatitude. By contrast, as regards those things that pertain to the active life, even the other animals in some sense have them in common with man, albeit imperfectly. And so the ultimate and perfect beatitude which we wait for in the future life consists as a whole in contemplation. By contrast, as *Ethics* 9 says, the sort of imperfect beatitude that can be had in this life (*qualis hic haberi potest*) consists first and principally in contemplation, but secondarily in the operation of the practical intellect, which orders human actions and passions.

Reply to objection 1: The proposed similarity of the practical intellect to God is a proportional likeness (*secundum proportionalitatem*); that is, the practical intellect is related to what it has cognition of (*ad suum cognitum*) in the way that God is related to what He has cognition of (*ad suum*). By contrast, the speculative intellect’s assimilation to God is through its being united to and informed by [Him] (*secundum unionem et informationem*)—which is a much greater similarity (cf. ST 1, q. 12, a. 5).

Still, one could also reply that with respect to the principal thing that He knows, viz., His own essence, God has only speculative cognition and not practical cognition.

Reply to objection 2: The practical intellect is ordered toward a good outside of itself, whereas the speculative intellect has its own good within itself, viz., the act of contemplating the truth. And if this good is perfect, then the whole man is perfected and made good by it. The practical intellect does not have this good, but instead orders things toward it.

Reply to objection 3: This argument would go through if a man himself were his own ultimate end, since in that case his beatitude would consist in his thinking about and ordering his actions and passions. But since man’s ultimate end is in fact an extrinsic good, viz., God, whom we attain through an operation of the speculative intellect, it follows that beatitude consists in an operation of the speculative intellect rather than in an operation of the practical intellect.

Article 6

Does man’s beatitude consist in the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences?

It seems that man’s beatitude consists in the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences (*in consideratione scientiarum speculativarum*):

Objection 1: In the *Ethics* the Philosopher says that happiness (*felicitas*) is an operation in accord with perfect virtue. And in distinguishing the virtues, he posits just three speculative virtues, viz., scientific knowledge (*scientia*), wisdom (*sapientia*), and understanding [of principles] (*intellectus*), all of which have to do with the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences. Therefore, man’s ultimate beatitude consists in the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences.

Objection 2: Ultimate human beatitude seems to be what is naturally desired for its own sake by everyone. But the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences is like this; for *Metaphysics* 1 says, “All men by nature desire to know,” and a little later it adds that the speculative sciences are sought

for their own sake. Therefore, beatitude consists in the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences.

Objection 3: Beatitude is ultimate human perfection, and each thing is perfected by being brought from potentiality to actuality. But the human intellect is brought to actuality by the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences. Therefore, it seems that man's ultimate beatitude consists in thinking of this sort.

But contrary to this: Jeremiah 9:23 says, "Let not the wise man glory in his wisdom," and it is speaking about the wisdom of the speculative sciences. Therefore, man's ultimate beatitude does not consist in the sort of thinking that belongs to these sciences.

I respond: As was explained above (a. 2), there are two types of human beatitude, the one *perfect* and the other *imperfect*. Perfect beatitude has to be thought of as attaining to the true nature of beatitude (*attinigit ad veram beatitudinis rationem*), whereas imperfect beatitude has to be thought of as not attaining to the true nature of beatitude, but instead as participating in a certain particular likeness of beatitude—in the way that perfect prudence is found in man, who has reason with respect to his actions, whereas imperfect prudence exists in some brute animals in whom there are particular instincts for certain actions that are similar to acts of prudence.

Perfect beatitude cannot consist essentially in the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences. To see this clearly, note that the sort of thinking that belongs to a speculative science does not extend beyond the strength of that science's principles, since the whole of a science is virtually contained in the principles of that science. Now as is clear from the Philosopher at the beginning of the *Metaphysics* and at the end of the *Posterior Analytics*, the first principles of the speculative sciences are received through the sensory power. Hence, the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences cannot as a whole extend further than the cognition of sensible things can lead one. But man's ultimate beatitude, which is his ultimate perfection, cannot consist in the cognition of sensible things. For nothing is perfected by something lower than itself unless the lower thing has some participation in a higher thing. But it is clear that the form of a rock—or the form of any sensible thing—is lower than a man. Hence, the human intellect is perfected by the form of a rock not insofar as it is a form of that sort, but rather insofar as it participates in some likeness of what is above the human intellect, viz., the intelligible light or something of that sort. But whatever exists through another (*per aliud*) is traced back to something that exists in its own right (*per se*); hence, man's ultimate perfection must come through the cognition of something that lies beyond the human intellect. But it has been shown (*ST* 1, q. 88, a. 2) that one cannot arrive at the cognition of separated substances, which lie beyond the human intellect, through sensible things. Hence, it follows that man's ultimate beatitude cannot lie in the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences.

However, just as sensible forms have a participated likeness to higher substances, so the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences is a certain participation in true and perfect beatitude.

Reply to objection 1: As was explained above (a. 2), in the *Ethics* the Philosopher is talking about the sort of imperfect happiness (*de felicitate imperfecta*) that can be had in this life.

Reply to objection 2: What is desired naturally is not just perfect beatitude, but also any sort of likeness of it or participation in it.

Reply to objection 3: Through the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences our intellect is brought in some sense to actuality, but not to its ultimate and complete actuality.

Article 7

Does man's beatitude consist in the cognition of the separated substances, i.e., the angels?

It seems that man's beatitude consists in the cognition of the separated substances, i.e., angels:

Objection 1: In a homily Gregory says, "It does not at all avail us to take part in the feasts of men, if we fail to take part in the feasts of the angels"—by which he means final beatitude. But we can take part in the feasts of the angels by contemplating them. Therefore, it seems that man's ultimate beatitude consists in contemplating the angels.

Objection 2: Each thing's ultimate perfection lies in its being joined to its source (*coniungatur suo principio*); thus, the circle is said to be a perfect figure because its source is the same as its end. But as Dionysius says in *De Caelesti Hierarchia*, chap. 4, the source of human cognition is from the angels themselves, by whom men are illuminated. Therefore, the perfection of the human intellect lies in contemplating the angels.

Objection 3: Each nature is perfected when it is joined to a higher nature; for instance, a body's ultimate perfection is to be joined to a spiritual nature. But in the order of nature the angels are higher than the human intellect. Therefore, the ultimate perfection of the human intellect is to be joined to the angels themselves by means of contemplation.

But contrary to this: Jeremiah 9:24 says, "But let him who glories glory in this, that he understands and knows me." Therefore, man's ultimate glory or beatitude consists only in the cognition of God.

I respond: As has been explained (a. 6), man's perfect beatitude does not consist in the perfecting of his intellect through any sort of participation; rather, it lies in what is such-and-such through its essence (*est per essentiam tale*). But it is clear that to the extent that any given thing constitutes the perfection of a power, it is such that the concept of that power's proper object applies to it. But the proper object of the intellect is the true. Therefore, whatever has participated truth does not, when contemplated, make the intellect perfect with its ultimate perfection.

Now since, as *Metaphysics* 2 says, entities have the same relation to *esse* that they have to truth, anything that is a being by participation is true by participation. But angels have participated being (*esse participatum*), since, as was shown in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 44, a. 1), it is only in the case of God that His *esse* is His essence. Hence, it follows that God alone is truth through His essence, and that God alone is such that contemplating Him makes one perfectly blessed.

On the other hand, nothing prevents a sort of imperfect beatitude from accompanying the contemplation of the angels; and this is a beatitude even higher than that found in the sort of thinking that belongs to the speculative sciences.

Reply to objection 1: We "take part in the feasts of the angels" by contemplating not only the angels but God along with them.

Reply to objection 2: According to those who claim that human souls are created by the angels, it seems appropriate enough that man's beatitude should lie in contemplating the angels and in being joined in this way to his source. However, as was explained in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 90, a. 3), this view is erroneous. Hence, man's ultimate perfection comes through his being joined to God, who is the first source (*principium*) both of the creation of the soul and of its illumination.

Now as was explained in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 111, a. 2), an angel does illuminate as a minister. Hence, by his ministry an angel helps a man to reach beatitude, but he is not the object of human beatitude.

Reply to objection 3: There are two possible ways to understand what it is for a higher nature to be reached (*atingi*) by a lower nature.

The first sense has to do with reaching the level of a participated power, and in this sense a man's

ultimate perfection will lie in the man's reaching the point of contemplating in the way that the angels contemplate.

The second sense has to do with a power's reaching its object, and in this sense the ultimate perfection of any power is to reach the thing in which the nature of the power's object is fully realized (*in quo plene invenitur ratio sui obiecti*).

Article 8

Does man's beatitude lie in his seeing God's very essence?

It seems that man's beatitude does not lie in his seeing God's very essence (*in visione ipsius divinae essentiae*):

Objection 1: In *Mystica Theologia*, chap. 1, Dionysius says that through the highest possible understanding, man is joined to God as to something altogether unknown. But what is seen through its essence is not altogether unknown. Therefore, the ultimate perfection of the intellect, viz., beatitude, does not consist in God's being seen through His essence.

Objection 2: To a higher nature belongs a higher perfection. But to see His own essence is a perfection peculiar to God's intellect (*perfectio divini intellectus propria*). Therefore, the human intellect's highest perfection does not reach this point, but stops somewhere short of it (*sed infra subsistit*).

But contrary to this: 1 John 3:2 says, "When He appears, we shall be like Him, and we shall see Him as He is."

I respond: There cannot be ultimate and perfect beatitude except in seeing God's essence. To see this clearly, there are two points that must be taken into account: the first is that a man is not perfectly happy as long as something remains to be desired and sought after; the second is that the perfection of any given power is in accord with the nature of its object.

Now as *De Anima* 3 says, an intellect's object is the 'what-ness', i.e., the essence, of a thing (*quod quid est, idest essentia rei*). Hence, an intellect's perfection goes as far as does its cognition of the essence of a thing. Therefore, if some intellect has a cognition of the essence of some *effect* but cannot thereby have a cognition of that effect's *cause*—i.e., a cognition by which the cause's 'what-ness' might be known—then that intellect is not said to have attained to the cause absolutely speaking (*non dicitur attingere ad causam simpliciter*), even though it is able, through the effect, to have a cognition of the cause's existence (*cognoscere possit de cause an sit*). And so when a man has a cognition of an effect and knows that it has a cause, there remains in him by nature a desire to know the 'what-ness' of the cause as well. And as the beginning of the *Metaphysics* says, this desire has its source in wonder (*illud desiderium est admirationis*) and leads to inquiry. For instance, if someone has a cognition of an eclipse of the sun, he realizes that it proceeds from some cause, which he wonders about because he does not know what it is, and in his wonder he makes an inquiry. And this inquiry is not put to rest until he arrives at a cognition of the essence of the cause.

Therefore, if the human intellect, knowing the essence of some created effect, knows of God only that He exists, then the intellect's perfection has not yet, absolutely speaking, reached the first cause; instead, there still remains in it a natural desire to make an inquiry into that cause. Hence, that intellect is not yet perfectly blessed.

Therefore, what is required for perfect beatitude is that the intellect should reach the very essence of the first cause. And so it will have its perfection by being united to God as its object, and, as was explained above (q. 2, a. 8), this alone is what man's beatitude consists in.

Reply to objection 1: Dionysius is talking about the cognition had by those who are still in this

life (*qui sunt in via*) and tending toward beatitude.

Reply to objection 2: As was explained above (q. 1, a. 8), there are two possible senses of ‘end’.

One of them has to do with the very thing which is desired, and in this sense the end of the higher nature is the same as the end of the lower nature—and, indeed, of all things, as was said above.

The other sense has to do with attaining this thing, and in this sense the end of the higher nature is different from the end of the lower nature in light of their diverse relations to the sort of thing in question. In this sense, then, God’s beatitude in comprehending His own essence is higher than the beatitude of a man or an angel who sees God but does not comprehend Him (cf. q. 4, a. 3 and *ST* 1, q. 12, a. 7).